‘Any country that privileges philosophy over plumbing will get both wrong. I saw the first budget of Mr Jaitley, God bless him, and thought to myself they were gone. UPA’s last budget was crazy. Essentially, it took all the earnings of next year and postponed all expenditures to next year. If a CFO of any private company would have done it, he would have been sacked or in jail. Modi government continued this approach of pushing the can further down the road.’[128]

Another senior economist, then on the Economic Advisory Council to the Prime Minister, compared Modi’s economic approach to Indira Gandhi’s. There is a view in the government, ‘like it was under UPA-2’, this economist said, ‘that economic growth is my birthright and would come anyway, so why bother so much’. In that sense, ‘these guys are more left than the Left’. When you question them on economic policy, ‘it becomes a question of loyalty—*aap kis ke saath hain?* [who are you with?]. We gave twenty-eight notes on how things can be changed. We should have been taking advantage of the China exodus after the financial crisis. But companies are going to Kenya and Vietnam. They don’t see it. They say, *yeh* growth *kee baat aap chor deejiye* [put aside this talk of growth]. We have just pulled so many million people out of poverty. The tragedy is that if this government, with its large majority, can’t reform India, no one else can. Then, we are doomed as a country.’

Another big issue that Modi critics identify is a relative lack of external expertise in the government. They are only relying on ‘bureaucrats’, said the former PMO bureaucrat. ‘They have set up committees but it is only a handful of babus who call the shots … Anyone who has fixed salary can’t do entrepreneurship,’ he said. This changed somewhat in 2019, when the government announced a series of lateral appointments of external experts at the joint secretary-level in nine ministries[129] and added several economists to the Economic Advisory Council to the Prime Minister.[130]

The challenge of balancing change with limited resources had other ramifications, which showed up most clearly in the defence sector: a key priority area in the discourse of the Modi government. In early 2020, when China broke the decades-long mutual